

THE FENECH TIMES

April 25, 2019 | 9012 Becker Ave., Allen Park, MI 48101 | (734) 752-9667 | anthonyfenech@hotmail.com

Shipping up to Boston

Experienced ball writer climbs career ladder

BY ANTHONY FENECH
The Fenech Times

BOSTON – I heard about this job from a National League executive, who sent me the link to the posting one night in spring training.

I met this man through a woman named Cynthia, who helped me pick out clothes at Banana Republic a week before my rookie year of spring training. Her son-in-law worked for a baseball team, she said, so I took his name down and e-mailed him.

This was many years after I first started reporting, in crayon, on notebook paper, the finished product called *The Fenech Times*. My mom would post them on the refrigerator. She claims she still has them somewhere.

This is where it all began, on my bedroom floor as the writer, editor and page designer.

These days, *The Fenech Times* is nearly out of circulation, only running for very special occasions. This, of course, is one of them: I am pursuing the best beat writing job in baseball, one steeped in tradition with Hall of Fame writers, a job that carries great responsibility in covering the religion that is Red Sox baseball.

In doing so, I'm going back to my roots. I am 31 years old now, no longer the editor or page designer, and the words I write show up in newsprint and on the Internet.

But this is me, and it's the passion and creativity I bring to the ballpark every day by just being myself, a writer who loves people and baseball.

By now, you know a little bit about me.

I came up at the Free Press, started by taking prep scores, did everything else along the way, and took over the Tigers beat five years ago. In that time, I've become one of the best beat writers in the country by providing a blend of unique coverage, from breaking news to taking readers behind-the-scenes with a touch of my personality.

But I have not done this alone.

The backbone of my success is the relationships I have built, relationships that extend far beyond the foul poles, many of which have developed into friendships.

The managers and coaches who continue to teach me the nuances of the game. Executives who point me in the right direction, scouts who want their voices heard and players, who, beneath the fame and fortune, are just regular dudes, too.

Clubhouse kids, broadcasters, fellow beat writers and most importantly, the fans we interact with on a daily basis, who are the reason we are able to work our dream jobs.

If there is one thing that separates me from the hundreds of applicants, however many finalists there may be, and the

competitive arena of baseball reporting itself, it is my success in building relationships.

These relationships are not defined by how many names are listed on a colorful spreadsheet, but the work that's put into them. And I have long since made it my top priority to build as many relationships as possible and continue strengthening them with trust.

Recently, I have leaned on those relationships in preparing for this opportunity.

Two weeks ago, I popped my head into Terry Francona's office and talked with him about what baseball in Boston is like.

"It's like Chicken Little every game," he said.

Last week, Alex Cora's older brother said he actually likes the beat writers. Red Sox vice president of communications Kevin Gregg said there is definitely an opportunity on this crowded beat for a young reporter to establish relationships.

And on Friday night, I found myself at a hotel bar with one of the first scouts I met, a Red Sox guy who said I would be a breath of fresh air for a fan base that gets fed panic by the masses.

A few weeks after my shopping spree that rookie year, I met Cynthia's son-in-law in Florida. He has since taken a promotion with another team and has become one of my best sources.

This is how I do what I do.

Red Sox reporting candidate Anthony Fenech: First year plan

With five years' experience on the baseball beat, I have created a plan to set the reporting foundation for my start on the Red Sox beat. This plan encompasses many of the core values I believe in.

Before I start: Contact my sources – major league and agents – and inform them of my new position. Ask agents which players and prospects in the organization they represent. Thank them for being accessible over the years, which has helped me out in my career.

Before I start: Identify each rival scout who covers the Red Sox organization by touching base, asking fellow scouts and/or introducing myself to rival scouting directors I have not yet communicated with.

Day 1: Introduce myself to key figures within the Globe and its sports department and the Red Sox organization via e-mail.

Week 1: Introduce myself to the clubhouse, wishing them good luck and good health this season. This includes players, coaches, trainers, media relations staff, clubhouse attendants. Depending how the introductions with players goes, ask who their agent is.

Week 1-Ongoing: Introduce myself to Red Sox nation, posting consistent gameday tweets, showing my personality to interact with fans to learn more about the fan base. Continue to learn and engage with Sox followers and Globe readers by responding swiftly to tweets, e-mails and direct messages. Follow players, staff and fan base influencers online.

Week 1-Ongoing: Stay in the clubhouse until it closes and dwell in the dugout as late as deadline possible. Talk to players about their outings – especially good outings, no matter how small – to begin building a relationship and trust.

Week 1: Sniff out the club house and identify focal points. Consider feature story possibilities, especially with star players and their families. Think David Price hanging out with Astro and his baby, and his pregnant-with-triplets wife. Talking with players' family members and writing a good story builds immense trust.

Week 2: Sit down with general manager Dave Dombrowski. This meeting will be completely off the record; I might not even bring my phone. Five years after last covering him, I will explain to Dave the kind of relationship I want to have with him, let him know how I go about doing my job and take the next step forward in building trust with transparency.

Week 2: Get together away from the park with manager Alex Cora, perhaps on a road trip. Managers are essential sources, perhaps underrated in these days when reporters must go through so many hoops to meet with people. Reporters must talk to the manager daily. I suspect I will have a very good relationship with Cora. He used to follow me on Twitter.

Week 2: Send first wave of introductory e-mails within the Red Sox organization, to major league scouts, area scouts and analytics department, to start relationships.

Week 3: Begin multi-story series profiling the Red Sox coaching staff. The coaches play an integral role in the clubhouse, hold a wealth of information and are often overlooked for credit. This will allow me to begin to build relationships with those coaches, give them some publicity, and create a very important pipeline in the clubhouse.

At some point: Visit each minor league city, so I can meet each manager, coach, top prospect, and other organizational figures. These people are very key in call-ups, send-downs and injuries.